

because we're not making these decisions every year doesn't mean those choices don't matter. They are the choices that matter most.

Every year you're likely to make some kind of significant housing or transportation decision. They're difficult to align with your values because there are so many factors going into one decision. But if you take your time with these big decisions, they make future smaller decisions easier or unnecessary. Luckily, there isn't a laundry list of decisions—80 percent of the time it's going to be one of these three:

Housing

Your mortgage or rent is your biggest expense month over month. If you don't own a home, the biggest housing decision you might be facing is “Should I buy a house or keep renting?” If you're a renter and want to continue renting, you have the most flexibility in lowering your monthly housing cost. You can negotiate your rent every year, but you can also live literally anywhere and move whenever you want. I (Jill) found the “third option” within this category by living in an RV for a few years. This allowed Eric and me to own within our means and reduce our living expenses significantly.

Now, your job, family, etc. may limit the ability for you to live in a vehicle like we did, but that doesn't negate flexibility. You can test out living somewhere new or in a smaller place for a year at a time, save some money, and if you don't like it, you can change. No decision is permanent, and you don't know what's gonna work for you until you try. If you're a renter looking to buy, then you have some extra questions to answer:

How long do you want to stay in the area?

Do you know how much square footage you need or are you guessing?

How much renovation do you want to do? And are you willing for the renovation timeline to be double your initial estimate?

Can you afford your own independent comprehensive inspection? (because you probably need it!)